



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Headington Hill Classical Academy
School Website: <https://headingtonhill.academy/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Headington Hill Classical Academy Mo 65804 (HHCA) demonstrates a strong classical Christian orientation with explicit commitments to virtuous character formation, a Trivium-based curriculum, and an integrated community model that partners with families. The school foregrounds God-centered learning, Scholé (restful learning), liturgical patterning, and a family-centric mission, while aiming to develop wisdom, virtue, and human flourishing. While HHCA clearly aligns with many core elements of classical education, some components (notably explicit reference to Great Books / Great Conversation and a fully Socratic high-school pedagogy) are less visibly articulated on public materials. Overall, HHCA is CLASSICAL, with room to strengthen a few explicit classical signals to reach a more unambiguous CLASSICAL designation.

Key insights: - Religious and metaphysical foundations are central: theology, liturgy, contemplation, and a Christian worldview anchor the curriculum and pedagogy. Evidence includes statements about living a Christ-centered education, a liturgical/Scholé approach, and a mission to form students in virtue and wisdom. See statements about living an abundant life in Christ, the Trivium, and liturgical learning.

- Purpose and goals emphasize formation and the pursuit of wisdom, virtue, and truth in a liberal-arts frame grounded in theology. Public materials repeatedly refer to forming character and reflecting God in learning.
- Curriculum centers the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Trivium, with explicit emphasis on integrated study and theological orientation. Evidence includes explicit references to the Trivium and a God-centered integration of all subjects.
- Pedagogy highlights contemplative/restful learning (Scholé), memorization/recitation patterns, and upper-level rhetoric and debate elements, with explicit mention of Scholé and liturgical pacing. Public materials show Scholé and liturgical framing; upper-school rhetoric and debate are noted in program descriptions.
- Faculty portrayal emphasizes trained, virtuous teachers who act as mentors and the living curriculum; the public pages describe classically trained teachers and a teacher-centered, mentorship-oriented approach.
- Parents & Community are foregrounded as co-teachers and partners in formation, with transparent openness to parent involvement and family-centered culture. The mission and value statements emphasize partnership with families and a family-centric model.

Overall, HHCA aligns with classical education principles across the six categories, with stronger signals in religious/metaphysical foundations, purpose/goal, curriculum, faculty, and parental/community engagement, and slightly weaker, but present, signals in explicit Great-Books-centric signals and fully articulated Socratic pedagogy in every grade. Aggregate rating: CLASSICAL.

Expanded category-by-category analyses follow, with keyword analytics grounded in the Classical Education Lexicon and the Six Essential Elements framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HHCA presents a Christian framework with explicit statements that education is centered on knowing God and living out Christian virtue. Examples include goals to “live an abundant life in Christ,” and statements that God is central to learning and that general revelation informs study. - Program language references Scholé, liturgical patterns, and contemplative formation as foundational to learning, signaling a sacred or liturgical dimension to education. - The mission emphasizes partnering with families to cultivate the love of truth, goodness, and beauty through a Christian worldview and Trivium-based study.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present (from the Six Essential Elements lexicon): truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; wonder; imago Dei; Logos; wisdom; reverence; sacred practices. The HHCA materials explicitly reference God, Christ, theology, liturgical practice, and contemplative learning, aligning with these signals. - Negative keywords: There is no visible pull toward secular humanism, relativism, or value-neutral ethics in the public materials. The material remains overtly theological and doctrinal. The lexicon’s negative signals (e.g., secularism, relativism) are not evidenced in HHCA’s public statements.

Why this rating - The public materials consistently position religion and metaphysical precepts at the center of education, with liturgical and contemplative practices, and theology integrated into learning. This satisfies the Positive indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and shows a robust classical orientation in this domain. The absence of negative signals supports CLASSICAL rather than NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements articulate formation over information: “to cultivate in their children the desire to love that which is lovely” and to think and learn through the Trivium toward wisdom and rhetoric; mission emphasizes formation, virtue, and wisdom rather than mere job preparation. - Purpose statements frame education as formation toward virtue and wisdom in a theologically integrated context, aligning with the classical aim of shaping character and intellect.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; human flourishing; wisdom; liberal education/paideia; great conversation; truth/goodness/beauty; telos. HHCA materials explicitly references formation and cultivation of virtue and wisdom in a God-centered frame. - Negative keywords: The site does not raise work-readiness or 21st-century-job prep as its primary aim; those concerns are not foregrounded as goals, which aligns with the classical formation emphasis. The lexicon flags college/career metrics as potential negative signals in some contexts, but HHCA does not foreground them.

Why this rating - HHCA’s stated goals and mission center formation, virtue, and wisdom over instrumental work-readiness, consistent with classical education’s purposeful aims. The presence of a robust formation language and the idea of “great conversation” (within a classical frame even if not always named explicitly) supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is structured around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a liberal-arts approach, with explicit mention of the Trivium and integration of subjects under a classical paradigm. The site highlights the Trivium progression and the aim to form through foundational texts and rigorous language/logic studies. - The program describes a God-centered, integrated curriculum and an emphasis on “foundational texts” and reading (classical training), with a focus on history, language, math, science, and reasoning to build a coherent body of knowledge.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Trivium; Great Books/Great Conversation signals are not always explicit on the site, but the language around “foundational texts” and the Trivium signals the liberal-arts, integrated curriculum core. The lexicon’s positive signals include Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, and integration of history with literature and philosophy. The site

demonstrates grammar, logic, and rhetoric, aligning with the category's core elements. - Negative keywords present: Explicit mentions of social-studies framing or project-based learning as replacements for history are not present; however, explicit Great-Books signaling is less visible in public materials. The lexicon lists potential negatives (e.g., "social studies terminology replacing history," "project-based learning dominance") that are not seen as the school's explicit approach.

Why this rating - HHCA clearly embraces the Trivium and liberal-arts framework, with integrated study and explicit focus on foundational texts and the Christian worldview. The lack of explicit public emphasis on Great Books and direct Socratic seminar structures in every grade signals it is strong but not yet fully explicit in all classical signals, yielding SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Restful, contemplative pedagogy is foregrounded (Scholé) and integrated through liturgical practices. The site emphasizes a contemplative pace, restfulness in learning, and a liturgical approach to classroom rhythm. - Upper-school pedagogy includes rhetoric, speech & debate, and opportunities to develop memory and rhetorical skill, consistent with classical aims. The site notes upper-level rhetoric and debate opportunities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: scholé (restful learning), contemplation, wonder, liturgy, rhetoric, speech, debate, memory work. These align with classical pedagogy signals. The lexicon identifies these as positive indicators for pedagogy and teaching methods. - Negative keywords present: The public materials do not emphasize experiential learning-only or student-led constructivist approaches; however, they do not consistently present the full spectrum of Socratic seminars or a fully ongoing Socratic culture in every grade. The explicit reference to Socratic seminar or Harkness-style discussion is not widely documented in public pages, so some classical pedagogy signals are present but not uniformly explicit.

Why this rating - The presence of Scholé, liturgical rhythm, and memory/chanting signals a strong classical pedagogy, but the explicit, systematic implementation of Socratic seminars across the upper grades is not clearly evidenced in the public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than CLASSICAL, given the partial but not universal visibility of core classical pedagogical practices.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe classically trained teachers who model virtue and act as mentors, with teachers described as the "living curriculum" and as core to the school. The site emphasizes teachers as role models and mentors; a portrait of what a teacher should be is implied in the materials. - Staff profiles and descriptions show faculty who bring classical training and a deep sense of vocation to their roles, reinforcing the classical living curriculum concept.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture. The lexicon lists these as classical faculty signals and mentor-teacher orientation. - Negative keywords present: Public materials do not reflect anti-classical faculty signals (e.g., "facilitators" or credential-only staff). No contrary signals are evident.

Why this rating - HHCA presents clear signals of a classical faculty model—teachers as virtuous mentors, living exemplars, and core to the school's mission. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL in the Faculty category.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - HHCA emphasizes partnership with families, parental formation, and open campus-like engagement. Mission statements describe working with parents to cultivate the love of truth and virtue and to form students in Christ, signaling a true co-educator model with family involvement. - The school markets itself as

family-centric and invites parent participation in events such as open houses, with documentation of family engagement practices on public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parents as co-teachers; parental formation; family-centered culture; open campus; home-school collaboration (as signaled in the school's materials and values). These align with the lexicon's Parent/Community signals. - Negative keywords present: No explicit signals of minimal parent involvement or consumerism; the site presents high levels of parent engagement and participation. The lexicon's negative signals are not evidenced in public materials.

Why this rating - The public materials clearly portray parents as co-educators and partners in classical formation, consistent with CLASSICAL in the Parents & Community category.

What Would Move the Needle

- For Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy), to shift toward full CLASSICAL, HHCA could:
 - Explicitly foreground and document in public materials a rigorous Great Books / Great Conversation program, including core readings across grades and a stated plan for textual study and dialogue centered on canonical works within Western civilization and Christian thought.
 - Expand on a clearly defined, school-wide implementation of Socratic seminars or Harkness-style discussions in upper grades, with teacher training, rubrics, and examples published on the site.
 - Provide detailed examples of lower-school singing/chanting and memory-work routines, including samples of chants, copybooks, or memorization practices used in class, to demonstrate concrete practices aligned with Six Essential Elements signals.
 - Publish a public mapping of how the Trivium progression (Grammar → Dialectic → Rhetoric) is implemented across grade bands, including assessment methods consistent with classical education.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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